Therefore, we grew up spending a lot of time outdoors in the countryside, exploring nature, hunting for 'ber' (wild berries), playing games like cops and thieves, marbles, 'gilli danda', kite-flying, spinning tops and later, badminton or cricket. Once we kids were invited to the flag staff house at Secunderabad, to fly kites with Major General Niranjan Prasad. We had great fun and enjoyed the hospitality of the large-hearted general!

We learnt to swim by being thrown into a deep 'hauzi' or water tank, with a rope tied around the waist. Once in the water, we had to splash around and keep afloat. We eventually learnt to swim, but the hard way. I had a sharp eye, a strong left arm that enabled me to chuck stones very effectively, and I was very accurate with my catapult too.

As boys, we gave a tough time to our parents as we would always be up to some mischief. When I was about ten or eleven years of age, I liked a girl and wrote 'ILY' followed by her name with a white chalk on the road that she would usually take to school. It was puppy love, I suppose. But I was found out, and the sound thrashing I got for this prank made me forget all such funny ideas thereafter! On another occasion, because of my long hair, I was asked to do the role of a lady in the school play. I raised quite a ruckus as I didn't want to be seen wearing female attire. The nuns then made me act as a 'princeling' with my hair curled up.

I am a left hander, also called a 'khabchu', like my late grandfather. However, in his case, he was compelled by circumstances to become a 'lefty'; as described earlier, he had been shot through his right elbow during the First World War. As a child, it was tough for me to stand constant nagging from family and friends for using the inauspicious or 'wrong' hand. Often, I would retort and say 'dadaji wang mainu vee doli lagi hai' (like grandpa, I too have a gunshot), pointing at my right hand. Hearing the stories of the Great War from the grand old soldier was the best pastime for us kids in that era.

The officers club used to be the hub of all social activities in the cantonments. There were sports facilities like tennis, badminton, squash and billiards, as well as a swimming pool. We made good use